

SCIENCE OF READING REVIEW: HARDING UNIVERSITY

ALTERNATIVE ROUTE

On-Site Review: Date not reported

WHAT'S IN THIS REPORT?

This report uses evidence from an on-site review to examine how an educator preparation program prepares candidates to teach reading using scientific reading instruction, as Arkansas requires of every approved program. It is meant to inform a continuous improvement process that takes educator preparation programs closer to the goals needed to serve Arkansas's students.

The on-site reviews are carried out by Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US), an external review organization. TPI-US teams inspect coursework and course materials, observe instruction and clinical practice, review program data, and hold focus groups with candidates, faculty, mentor teachers, and school partners. Division of Elementary and Secondary Education staff participate in the review.

TPI-US rates the program in the three review areas of the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

- Review Area 1, "Quality of Literacy Coursework," is rated from course materials, syllabi, assignments, and observations of instruction.
- Review Area 2, "Quality of Field-Based Experiences," is rated from placement records, observation and feedback evidence, and focus groups with candidates, mentor teachers, faculty, and school partners.
- Review Area 3, "Quality of Performance Management and Continuous Improvement," is rated from program data systems, quality-control checkpoints, monitoring practice, and partnership evidence.

Every review area receives a rating. Depending on the framework version, the report may also rate each criterion; some earlier reports discuss every criterion without stating a separate rating for it. Performance Levels are defined as follows, in language drawn from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

PERFORMANCE LEVEL	WHAT THE RATING MEANS
4 — EXCEEDS	Coursework and training CONSISTENTLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
3 — MEETS	Coursework and training USUALLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
2 — APPROACHING	Coursework and training INCONSISTENTLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
1 — BELOW	Coursework and training RARELY OR DO NOT address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.

HARDING UNIVERSITY

ALTERNATIVE ROUTE

REVIEW AREA PERFORMANCE LEVELS		
REVIEW AREA 1 LITERACY COURSEWORK	REVIEW AREA 2 FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES	REVIEW AREA 3 PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT
APPROACHING	APPROACHING	APPROACHING
CRITERIA REVIEWED		
9	11	7
CORRECTIVE ACTION STATUS		
Corrective action plan in place for this review cycle. This program is carrying out a corrective action plan with the Division covering fifteen actions.		

PROGRAM INFORMATION

INSTITUTION NAME	Harding University
LOCATION	Searcy, Arkansas
PROGRAM REVIEWED	Master of Arts in Teaching (MAT), literacy; a nontraditional, online graduate program offering two tracks, with Track 1 candidates serving as teachers of record and Track 2 candidates completing a student teaching placement
PATHWAY	Alternative Route
REVIEW FRAMEWORK	TPI-US Arkansas SOR Review Framework (2024)
REVIEWING BODY	Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US)
SITE VISIT DATES	Not reported

REVIEW AREA 1: QUALITY OF LITERACY COURSEWORK

REVIEW AREA 1 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
APPROACHING 9 criteria reviewed	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Overview of the science of reading	Meets
Concepts of print instruction	Approaching
Collaborative communication, oral language instruction	Approaching
Phonological and phonemic awareness instruction	Meets
Phonics, orthography, automatic word recognition instruction	Meets
Fluency instruction	Approaching
Vocabulary instruction	Approaching
Text comprehension instruction	Approaching
Writing instruction	Below
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND	
Reviewers examined two literacy courses in the MAT program, RDNG 6450, English Language and Structure for Teachers, and SPED 6500, Interdisciplinary Literacy, together with course syllabi, course observations and instructor interviews. Three criteria met expectations. Coursework grounded candidates in the science of reading through the Simple View of Reading, Scarborough's Reading Rope, Ehri's phases of word recognition and orthographic mapping, and the Four-Part Processing Model, and it built content knowledge in phonological and phonemic awareness and in phonics, orthography and automatic word recognition, including the 44 phonemes, Elkonin boxes, syllable types and morphology. Candidates critiqued structured language programs using a T-chart aligned to multisensory program criteria and were introduced to CTOPP-2, PAT-2, PAST, DSA, TWS-4 and OWLS-II. Five criteria were approaching. Reviewers found limited modeling and few required opportunities to plan, deliver and receive feedback on concepts of print, oral language, fluency, vocabulary and text comprehension routines. Writing instruction was below expectations, with few modeled mini-lessons and weak assessment practice beyond the Cross-Curricular Writing and Genre Unit.	
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS	
• Strengthen candidates' ability to teach writing by teaching how writing occurs across the curriculum and how reading and writing reinforce each other, building in assessment knowledge and the skill to differentiate for multilingual learners and for students at different stages of writing development • Ensure every candidate has frequent, meaningful chances to practice coursework concepts in real classroom settings, including videoing their own teaching as teachers of record and submitting those recordings for feedback from literacy faculty	
CORRECTIVE ACTIONS TARGETING THIS AREA	
Four of the twelve corrective actions target this review area.	

REVIEW AREA 2: QUALITY OF FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES

REVIEW AREA 2 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
APPROACHING 11 criteria reviewed	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Selection of clinical placement schools	Not Scored
Selection of cooperating teachers (mentor teachers)	Approaching
Opportunities to observe models of effective early literacy practice	Approaching
Field-based placements provide opportunities to use HQIM	Exceeds
Responsibilities build to candidate readiness for full responsibility	Approaching
Opportunities to apply learning about multilingual children	Approaching
Opportunities to apply learning about students who experience difficulty reading	Approaching
Mentor teachers are skillful and can coach candidates	Approaching
Faculty and supervisors guide and evaluate candidates through training	Approaching
Quality of written and oral feedback	Approaching
Student engagement and candidate impact on student learning	Approaching
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND	
Reviewers interviewed faculty, university supervisors and partnership districts serving Track 2 candidates, and reviewed recorded observations of candidates teaching in their own classrooms. Selection of clinical placement schools was not scored because Track 1 candidates are teachers of record hired by principals across the state and Track 2 accounts for about 2 percent of enrollment. Field-based use of high-quality instructional materials exceeded expectations, supported by the program director's beginning-of-year call with each district to identify the adopted materials. The remaining nine criteria were approaching. Candidates engaged struggling readers through 20 hours of observation in SPED 6210 and semester-long tutoring of one reader in RDNG 6450, and applied learning about multilingual students through the Diverse Learners Project and two case studies. Reviewers found that mentor selection did not test for science of reading expertise, that the eight annual observations were not always specific to literacy content, and that supervisor feedback missed instructional errors, including inaccurate phoneme production and unexplained phonics rules.	
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS	
• Train all literacy faculty and supervising practitioners to give high-quality post-observation oral and written feedback that addresses impact on student learning and provides actionable next steps, and hold regular calibration meetings to analyze candidate performance data • Improve the quality of oral and written feedback so that it is tied to prior feedback and to student learning, and make that feedback an integral part of the monitoring system so results can be reviewed and used to strengthen coursework and training	
CORRECTIVE ACTIONS TARGETING THIS AREA	
Six of the twelve corrective actions target this review area.	

REVIEW AREA 3: QUALITY OF PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT AND CONTINUOUS IMPROVEMENT

REVIEW AREA 3 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
APPROACHING 7 criteria reviewed	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Quality of data the program collects and uses	Meets
Internal quality control gates (or checkpoints) and intervention plans	Meets
Quality of monitoring	Approaching
Monitoring coursework quality, teaching quality, and clinical connections	Approaching
Quality improvement planning	Approaching
Partnerships improve candidate experiences with HQIM	Exceeds
Evaluation of partnerships for readiness to teach early literacy	Approaching
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND	
Reviewers examined the program's data systems, checkpoints, monitoring practices and district partnerships. Quality of data and internal quality control gates met expectations. The program draws on observation cycle data, science of reading rubric results, key assessment data, foundations of reading scores, candidate tracking sheets showing completed courses and Praxis results, and residency and student survey data, and it has a formal intervention process with criteria and an action plan template in the handbook, although that process has not yet been used. Partnerships with districts on high-quality instructional materials exceeded expectations. Four criteria were approaching. Supervisors attend an annual training covering co-teaching protocols, required rubrics and inter-rater reliability on numeric scores, but no training addresses the delivery of effective oral and written feedback. Leaders record next steps in meeting minutes without measurable goals, do not share data widely with stakeholders, and make the instructional videos that broaden candidate experience optional.	
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS	
• Create a process for collecting and monitoring feedback on literacy lessons, including oral debriefs and written comments, and systematically monitor the quality of coursework and teaching so that gaps in candidates' classroom literacy instruction result in coursework revisions • Use the results of feedback monitoring as part of the program's quality control gates and improvement planning, and convene a stakeholder council of faculty, supervisors, mentor teachers and district partners to review those results and set action plans with measurable goals	
CORRECTIVE ACTIONS TARGETING THIS AREA	
Three of the twelve corrective actions target this review area.	

CORRECTIVE ACTION

Where a review identifies findings that require follow-up, the program develops a corrective action plan with the Division of Elementary and Secondary Education. The recommendations under each review area above are the reviewers' advice; the plan below is the program's formal response, monitored by the Division. Actions are grouped by the review area whose findings prompted them.

TOTAL ACTIONS	HIGH PRIORITY	MEDIUM PRIORITY	LOW PRIORITY
12	4	7	1

The plan sets out 15 corrective actions: 12 high priority and 3 medium priority. The priorities are the plan's own. Some actions target more than one review area, so the per-area counts shown under each review area add to more than the total.

ACTIONS THE PROGRAM IS TAKING

PRIORITY	ACTION	FINDING THAT REQUIRED IT	SUCCESS METRICS
HIGH RA1	Course Revisions (writing modules); Literacy Foundations for English Learners book study	Writing instruction rated Below; program provides few concrete exemplars of modeled writing instruction	Exemplar library covers all taught genres; every candidate delivers ≥2 coached writing lessons and administers a writing assessment; ≥85% proficient on the writing rubric; documented differentiation for multilingual and developing writers
HIGH RA1	Course Revisions; Lesson Plan Internalization Training (TNTP); WalkThrough Tool Training	Approaching across concepts of print, oral language, fluency, vocabulary, and text comprehension where reviewers repeatedly found conceptual foundations present but application limited	Every SOR component carries a required application task; ≥1 self-video submission per component with faculty feedback; ≥85% of candidates proficient on component performance tasks
HIGH RA2	Cognitive Coaching Training; WalkThrough Tool Training	Program provided training rated Approaching: some literacy faculty and supervising practitioners trained to provide highquality postobservation oral and written feedback; lack of calibration meetings	100% of literacy faculty and supervising practitioners trained; calibration meetings held on the published cadence; inter-rater agreement ≥0.80 on POP cycle and SOR rubric scoring
HIGH RA2	Cognitive Coaching Training; WalkThrough Tool Training	Feedback quality rated Approaching; supervisors occasionally identify helpful refinements; inconsistently call out instructional issues affecting student understanding	≥90% of sampled feedback states student-learning impact and actionable next steps; SOR accuracy errors identified in observed lessons rather than overlooked; documented improvement in feedback quality after training
MEDIUM RA2	Defined Partnerships/ Collaboration with Dyslexia Specialists at COOPs; Identify HQIM in all partner districts	Selection of cooperating teachers Approaching; mentor teacher evidence-based practices and coaching candidates Approaching; does not take additional steps to ensure mentors are selected for capacity to mentor SOR instruction and to model it.	SOR mentor criteria adopted and applied to 100% of mentors; verification on file for every mentor; mentor PD tracked for those not yet meeting the bar

PRIORITY	ACTION	FINDING THAT REQUIRED IT	SUCCESS METRICS
MEDIUM RA1	Course Revisions; Small Group Instruction Training K-2 and 3-6	Concepts of print, oral language, and fluency all Approaching; concepts of print named and connected to early literacy knowledge; carry no dedicated assignment requiring candidates to plan or model instruction; oral language provides conceptual foundation with limited application; fluency adequately introduced; sequence of instruction uneven and modeled strategies minimally reflect strong evidence.	Dedicated application assignment documented for each of the three components; fluency instruction sequence published and evidence-checked; every candidate administers an assessment in each area; ≥85% proficient
MEDIUM RA1	Course Revisions	Vocabulary and text comprehension both Approaching; program builds a substantial knowledge base in both areas with research-aligned texts and strategy modeling videos; application opportunities limited relative to the depth of content coverage.	Required delivery and assessment tasks documented for both components; every candidate submits a vocabulary and a comprehension lesson for feedback; ≥85% proficient on both performance tasks
MEDIUM RA2	Inclusive Practices Training; Defined Partnerships/ Collaboration with Dyslexia Specialists at COOPs; Literacy Foundations for English Learners book study	Candidates' opportunities to apply learning about language and literacy development in multilingual children Approaching; opportunities to apply learning about students who experience difficulty reading, including dyslexia and Tier 1 and Tier 2 practices, Approaching.	Every candidate documents multilingual and Tier 1/Tier 2 practice or simulation; ≥1 intervention cycle with reflection per candidate; book study completed with applied evidence
MEDIUM RA2	Lesson Plan Internalization Training (TNTP); Cognitive Coaching Training	Student engagement and candidate impact on student learning Approaching; inconsistent preparation and delivery; some instances demonstrate interruptions in lesson flow	≥85% of candidates proficient on a readiness and engagement task; observed lessons show materials prepared at the start; documented reduction in off-task time
MEDIUM RA3	Walk-Through Tool Training; Course Revisions	Quality of monitoring and coursework monitoring both Approaching; lacking process for collecting and monitoring feedback on literacy lessons; ensure literacy faculty who teach the courses aware of clinical performance; revise coursework where gaps in candidates' ability to teach literacy concepts appear	Monitoring process live and mirroring the UG program; calendar executed with no missed windows; literacy faculty receive clinical performance data each term; revision decisions traceable to monitoring findings
MEDIUM RA3	Full Program Revision (planning and gates); Identify HQIM in all partner districts	Quality improvement planning and partnership evaluation both Approaching; use results of feedback monitoring as part of program's quality control gates and overall improvement planning; findings on oral and written feedback feed strategic planning and guide candidate specific action plans.	Council seated and meeting on cadence with all four constituencies represented; monitoring results used at every gate decision; plan adopted with measurable goals and owners; action plan on file for every candidate needing improvement
LOW RA2, RA3	Identify HQIM in all partner districts and incorporate into revised coursework	HQIM use in placements rated Exceeds; partnership quality with HQIM aligned to the Literacy Review Criteria rated Exceeds; district outreach model secures HQIM access for teacher-of-record candidates and the depth of theoretical framework instruction.	Outreach process documented in program handbooks; HQIM inventory current for all districts employing candidates

OVERSIGHT

Each action in the plan carries an evidence requirement and a rationale tied to a review finding. The plan leaves the responsible owner and the completion timeline for program leadership to assign, so those entries are not recorded in the plan as issued and are not published here. Review area assignments in the table were made by

matching each action's stated rationale to the review area whose findings it answers. *Sources: TPI-US Arkansas Literacy Review, Harding University, site visit dates not reported in the review report, conducted under the TPI-US Arkansas SOR Review Framework (2024). Rating scale language quoted from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework.*